

What the data shows about the Upper East Side's Legionnaires' cooling towers

This summer, 76 buildings in Manhattan were ordered to scrub their rooftop cooling towers after tests found *Legionella* bacteria. We compared those buildings against their neighbors using the city's public records. Here's what stands out — in plain language.

Upper East Side • Carnegie Hill & Yorkville ZIP 10028 • 10075 • 10128 Updated July 2026



First, the reassuring part

The NYC Health Department says it remains **safe to shower, drink tap water, and use air conditioners** in the affected ZIP codes. Rooftop cooling towers are part of a building's air-conditioning system — separate from the water you drink and bathe in. Legionnaires' disease does not spread from person to person.

In early July 2026, health investigators noticed a cluster of Legionnaires' disease — a serious, treatable form of pneumonia — in the Carnegie Hill and Yorkville sections of the Upper East Side. They sampled water from more than 180 rooftop cooling towers in the area. Where a screening test came back positive for *Legionella*, the building was ordered to clean and disinfect its tower immediately, as a precaution. That list has grown to **76 buildings**.

Cooling towers matter because they release a fine mist into the outdoor air. If *Legionella* is growing inside one, that mist can carry the bacteria to people nearby. It's why cooling towers have been the source of past New York outbreaks — and why the city regulates, registers, and tests them.

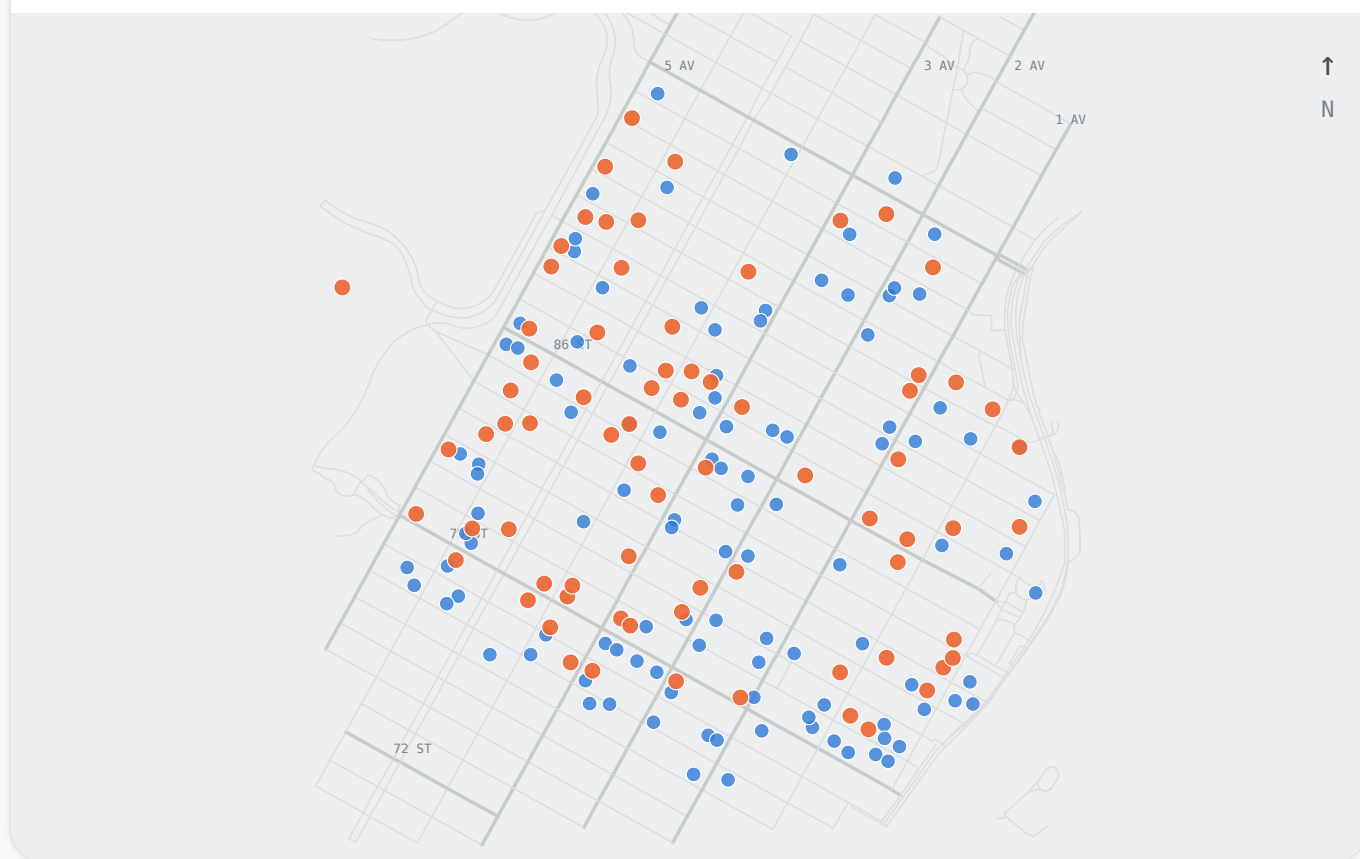
What we looked at

Every cooling tower in NYC has to be registered, tested for *Legionella* on a schedule, and inspected. All of that is public. We took the **76 buildings whose towers tested positive** and compared them against the **other registered cooling-tower buildings in the same three ZIP codes** — 183 buildings in all — asking a simple question: *do the positive buildings have anything different about their history?*

THE OUTBREAK ZONE, TOWER BY TOWER

Positive and negative towers sit side by side

● Tested positive — ordered to clean (74) ● Registered tower, not on the list (109)



Each dot is a building's cooling tower, at its real location. Hover (or tap) for details. Orange towers tested positive; blue did not. Notice they're mixed together — there is no single block or corner that stands out.

Four things the data says

01

It's about where, not who

About **40%** of towers inside the outbreak ZIP codes tested positive — versus almost none elsewhere in Manhattan. By far the biggest factor in a positive result is simply being in the affected neighborhood.

02

Not a story of neglect

Buildings with more violations, overdue tests, or fewer inspections were **not** more likely to test positive. The usual signs of a poorly-run building did not predict *Legionella*.

03

Bigger buildings, more testing

Positives leaned toward **larger, higher-value buildings that test their towers more often** — most likely because the more you test, the more you catch. It isn't evidence those buildings are worse-run.

04

No single hotspot

Positive and negative towers are **intermixed block by block**. Statistically, there's no tight cluster — consistent with bacteria turning up diffusely across the area rather than from one point.

The one number that matters most

If you remember nothing else: a tower's odds of testing positive were driven overwhelmingly by *location*, not by how well its building kept up with the rules.

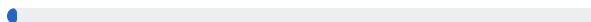
40%

of towers **in the outbreak ZIPs** tested positive



0.07%

of towers **elsewhere in Manhattan**



What this means for you

The cleaning orders are a **precaution**: a positive screening test doesn't guarantee live, infectious bacteria were present, so the city cleans first and confirms later. Our analysis found no evidence pointing at specific "negligent" buildings — so there's little to be gained from worrying about which address you live near. The sensible steps are the ordinary ones: follow the Health Department's guidance, and take symptoms seriously.

Know the signs

Legionnaires' disease usually appears **2-10 days** after exposure and is treatable with antibiotics, especially when caught early. Symptoms include:

- Fever, chills, cough
- Shortness of breath, chest discomfort
- Muscle aches, headache, sometimes diarrhea or confusion

Risk is higher for people **50 and older**, smokers, and those with chronic lung conditions or weakened immune systems. If you live or spent time in the area and have these symptoms, **see a doctor and mention the outbreak**. For questions, call **311**.

What this analysis can't tell you

- It's built on **which towers tested positive**, not on where sick people live — patient locations are private and never published.
- It can show patterns, but it **can't prove what caused** any individual infection.
- It's a snapshot of a fast-moving investigation; the official building list and case counts keep changing.
- With 74 positive buildings, the numbers are small — the findings are suggestive, not the final word.

How we did it. We matched the Health Department's public "clean & disinfect" list to NYC's Cooling Tower Registration and Inspection datasets on [NYC Open Data](#), then compared the positive buildings against other registered cooling-tower buildings in the same ZIP codes using standard statistics (logistic regression and a spatial clustering test). Building size and value come from the city's PLUTO dataset. Street map from NYC's Street Centerline. A full technical writeup accompanies this piece.

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